Electron-Ion Path Integral Monte Carlo

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I. INTRODUCTION

Hydrogen is the simplest element in the Universe. It has a nucleus made of only one proton, the ion, and an orbiting electron. An interesting question is whether the laws of quantum statistical physics are able to reproduce the *formation of the Hydrogen atoms* given a plasma made of an equal number of electrons and protons, a Two-Component-Plasma (TCP). This problem has been widely studied in literature starting from the pioneering exact analytic study of the non quantum TCP in one dimension of Edwards and Lenard [1, 2] to reach the realistic first principles ground state Monte Carlo calculations of Ref. [3] and non zero temperature Path Integral Monte Carlo (PIMC) calculations of Refs. [4, 5] or the coupled electron-ion Monte Carlo [6] where the ground state properties of the electrons component are used to perform a PIMC calculation on the protons component only.

There are many non quantum simulations of the TCP studying the clustering and phase transition properties [7]. Here we want to study the quantum version specializing to the electron-proton binary mixture with a 1:1 ratios between the particle numbers of the two species. This will allow us to investigate the Hydrogen atom formation problem.

We then start from a completely ionized TCP with a number of electrons $N_e = N/2$ equal to the number of protons $N_p = N/2$ in a volume Ω and in thermal equilibrium at an inverse temperature $\beta = 1/k_B T$ with k_B Boltzmann constant and T the absolute temperature. We use a PIMC calculation [8] with a number $M = \beta/\tau$ of timeslices of length τ which discretize the imaginary time interval $[0, \beta[$ to determine the thermodynamic and structural properties of the plasma. In particular the structural clustering that we observe proves the ability of the quantum statistical physics theory to predict the atom formation from first principles when one introduces just Coulomb pair interactions. [1]

Since the proton is about 2000 times more heavy than the electron we expect the protons species paths to be much more contracted than the ones of the electrons species. But, as we will see, this occurrence does not pose any serious limitation to what can be simulated but only an increase of the computer time needed to measure the properties of the protons component.

We know that both the electron and the proton are spin 1/2 identical particles and as such they each obey to the Fermi-Dirac statistics. But as we will see there is just a slight difference between treating both species as fermions or as bosons. This is essentially due to the property of bosons to 'like' themselves and of the fermions to 'dislike' themselves. Of course while bosons simulations are exact, fermions simulations are affected by the so called 'fermions

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[1] It would be interesting to see if, for more complicated atoms, the introduction of nuclear forces would still make it possible to predict the atom formation.

sign problem' [9] which can be overcome only by approximate methods like the Restricted PIMC (RPIMC) [10]. The approximate RPIMC for fermions is much more slow than the exact PIMC for bosons since it requires the calculation of M determinants of dimension $N/2$ at each Metropolis attempted move [11]. So that only small N systems can be studied.

Due to the divergence of the Coulomb potential at the origin like $1/r$ it is necessary to introduce a hard core σ for the nuclei, the protons, while we will consider the electrons as dimensionless and pointwise. This is needed in order to obtain a stable many body system that does not collapse. As we will see, for a given temperature T, the minimum hard core diameter preventing the collapse will be dependent from temperature, $\sigma = \sigma_{\rm min}(T)$.

Metallic Hydrogen

Let us consider a mixture of electrons, e, and protons, p. In reduced units we will consider $\hbar = k_B = 1$. We measure masses in units of the electron mass m_e so that the reduced mass of the electron will be $\mu_e = m_e/m_e = 1$ and the reduced mass of the proton $\mu_p = m_p/m_e \approx 1836.15$. The characteristic kinetic energy is

$$\mathscr{K} = \frac{\hbar^2}{2m_e\ell^2}, \tag{1.1}$$

with ℓ a length. The characteristic Coulomb energy is

$$\mathscr{V} = \frac{e^2}{\ell} = \frac{2\mathscr{K}\ell}{\mathscr{L}}, \tag{1.2}$$

with e the electron charge magnitude and

$$\mathscr{L} \approx 5.29177 \times 10^{-9}\text{cm} \tag{1.3}$$

a characteristic length. Then, if we denote with $n = N/\Omega$ the reduced number density this will correspond to a real number density of $n\mathscr{L}^{-3}$. For example for metallic hydrogen we have a mass density $\approx 1\text{g/cm}^3$ which corresponds to a reduced density of $n \approx \mathscr{L}^3/m_p \approx 0.0885943$.

We may then take as characteristic temperature

$$\mathscr{T} = \frac{\mathscr{K}\ell^2}{\mathscr{L}^2 k_B} \approx 315775\text{K}. \tag{1.4}$$

So that for metallic hydrogen in planetary interiors an absolute temperature of $\approx 10^5$K will correspond to a reduced temperature of $T \approx 10^5/\mathscr{T} \approx 0.0316681$.

The size of the nucleus of the hydrogen atom is $\approx 2 \times 10^{-13}$cm which in reduced units is $\sigma \approx 3.77945 \times 10^{-5}$. On the other hand we will consider the electrons as pointwise. That diameter of the hydrogen nucleus is too small to grant stability of the mixture against collapse. In fact the electrons will collapse onto the protons as soon as their kinetic energy is less than the Coulomb attraction at contact, namely

$$\frac{1}{2T} \lesssim \frac{2}{\sigma}, \tag{1.5}$$

in reduced units. So that $\sigma_{\rm min} \sim 4T$.

The Hamiltonian and the density matrix in reduced units will then read

$$H = K + V = -\sum_{\alpha=1}^{N} \frac{1}{2\mu_{i_\alpha}} \nabla_\alpha^2 + \sum_{\alpha<\beta=1}^{N} \phi_{i_\alpha i_\beta}(r_{\alpha\beta}), \tag{1.6}$$

$$\rho = e^{-H/T}. \tag{1.7}$$

where we indicate with a Greek index the particle label and with a Roman index the species label so that for example i_α is the species label of particle α, either 1 for the electrons or 2 for the protons, $\boldsymbol{r}_\alpha$ is the position vector of particle α, and $r_{\alpha\beta} = |\boldsymbol{r}_{\alpha\beta}| = |\boldsymbol{r}_\alpha - \boldsymbol{r}_\beta|$ is the distance between particles α and β. Distances are measured in units of $\mathscr{L}$. The reduced masses are then $\mu_1 = \mu_e$ and $\mu_2 = \mu_p$. The partial pair potential ϕ_{ij} is the usual Coulomb potential given by

$$\phi_{ij}(r) = \begin{cases} \epsilon_{ij}/r & r > \Sigma_{ij} \\ \infty & \text{else} \end{cases}, \tag{1.8}$$

where in the Two-Component-Plasma (TCP) we choose

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \tag{1.9}$$

$$\boldsymbol{\Sigma} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \sigma/2 \\ \sigma/2 & \sigma \end{pmatrix}. \tag{1.10}$$

Note that at a given T if we choose σ too small the whole system collapses with all the negative light particles falling on the heavy positive particles.

We will indicate with N_i the number of particles of species $i = 1, 2$ and $N = \sum_i N_i$ the total number of particles with $x_i = N_i/N$ the molar fraction for species i such that $\sum_i x_i = 1$. The reduced partial number densities $n_i = nx_i$ with $n = N/\Omega$ and in a cubic box $\Omega = L^3$, with L the reduced length of the side of the box. The box can be made periodic so that it permeates the whole infinite three dimensional space in order to mimic the thermodynamic limit. This will produce finite size errors that can be reduced by increasing the box size L. Of course in order to study a given thermodynamic state of the system this requires increasing L at constant density n which means increasing N. This will make the computer experiment more demanding from the numerical calculation cost point of view.

Moreover, in periodic boundary conditions the potential energy V for the particles within the central box should include also the pair interactions with all their images in the periodic boxes. Since the Coulomb potential $1/r$ is long range these contributions cannot generally be neglected and specific techniques should be used [12] to treat them, the most common of which is the Ewald summation. In this preliminary work we will simply neglect interactions with periodic images since we will not carry out a careful finite size error analysis.

We performed some computer experiments as described in Table I. During the simulations we measured some thermodynamic quantities as the total kinetic energy and potential energy of the TCP and the superfluid fractions for each species. These were measured using the thermodynamic estimators described in Ref. [8]. And we also calculated the partial and total radial distribution functions. Given an observable $\mathscr{O}$ we can measure it during the simulation through the following PIMC operation [8]

$$\langle \mathscr{O} \rangle = \mathrm{tr}(\rho \mathscr{O})/Z, \tag{1.11}$$

$$Z = \mathrm{tr}(\rho), \tag{1.12}$$

where ρ is the density matrix of Eq. (1.7) and Z is the canonical partition function. Therefore we impose both spatial and imaginary time periodic boundary conditions for the many body path of both species $R(t) = (\boldsymbol{r}_1(t), \boldsymbol{r}_2(t), \ldots, \boldsymbol{r}_N(t))$ so that for any function f we require $f(R + LU) = f(R)$ with $U = (1, 1, \ldots, 1)$ a $3N$ vector and $R(t + \beta) = R(t)$ with $\beta = 1/T$ the reduced inverse temperature.

TABLE I. Cases treated in our simulations for the TCP. The reduced masses of the two species are $\mu_1 = 1$ and μ_2, the molar fractions $x_1 = 1 - x_2$ and x_2, σ the hard core of species 2, the total number of particles N, the reduced density $n = N/\Omega$, the reduced inverse temperature $\beta = 1/T$, $e_K = \langle K \rangle/N$ the total kinetic energy per particle, $e_V = \langle V \rangle/N$ the total potential energy per particle, $f_s(i)$ the superfluid fraction for species i. These three thermodynamic quantities are measured from the thermodynamic estimators discussed in Ref. [8]. The other quantities were introduced in the main text. In the statistics column "b" stands for bosons, "f" for fermions. The simulation lasted more than 10^8 Monte Carlo steps where one step is made of a displace move of all the beads of a single particle path and a bridge move.

case	statistics	β	M	n	N	x_2	μ_2	σ	Ne_K	Ne_V	$f_s(1)$	$f_s(2)$
A	b (PIMC)	10	20	0.1	20	0.5	1000	0.4	5.422(5)	12.423(9)	0.479(1)	0.04744(2)
B	f (RPIMC)	10	20	0.1	20	0.5	1000	0.4	5.35(1)	12.26(2)	0.488(2)	0.04744(6)

From Fig. 1 we see the formation of clusters made of an heavy positive particle (of species 2) surrounded by a cloud of light negative particles (of species 1). We also see how changing the statistics between particles of the same species from Bose-Einstein to Fermi-Dirac makes them dislike themselves more as expected from the Pauli exclusion principle. This is confirmed by the snapshots of Fig. 2. From the snapshots we see how the light and fast electrons are in the quantum regime with extended paths and the heavy and slow protons are in the classical regime with contracted paths.

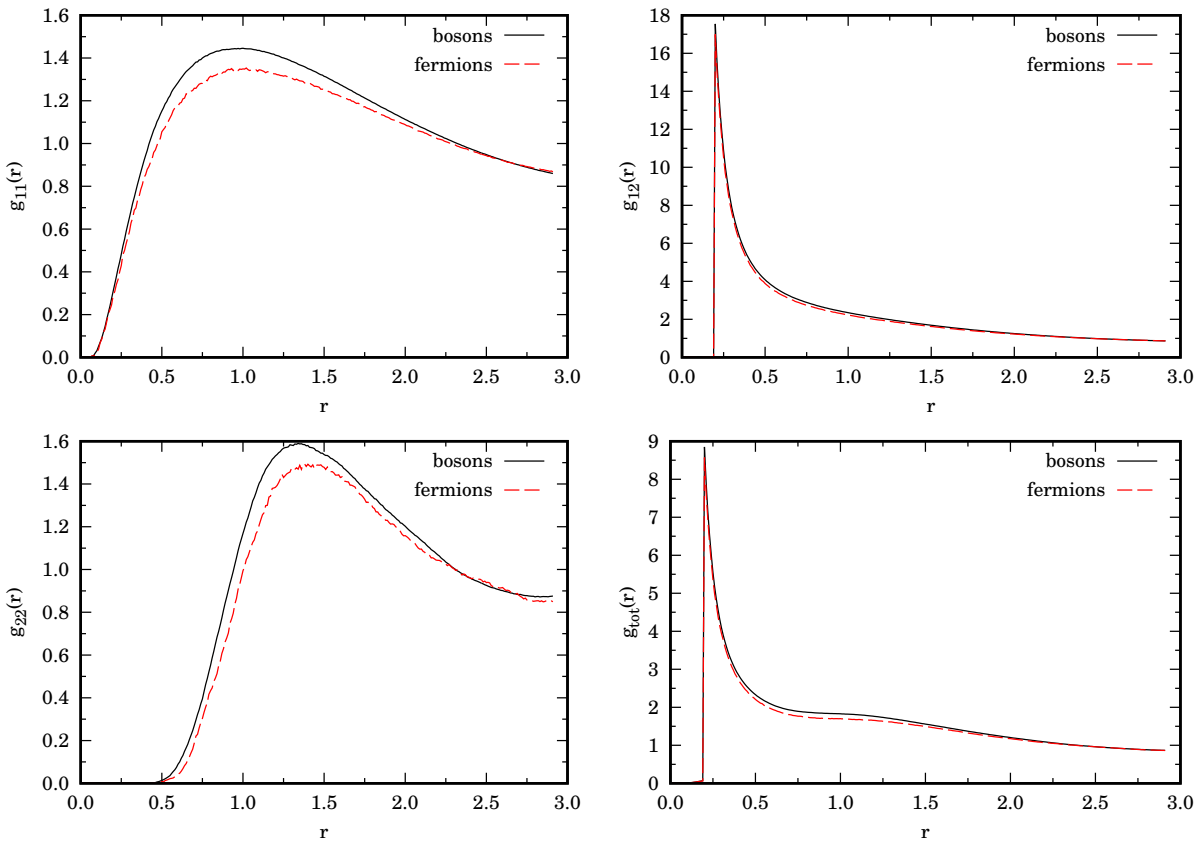

FIG. 1. The partial, g_{ij}, and total, g_{tot}, radial distribution functions for a binary mixture with $N = 20, x_1 = 1/2, \mu_1 = 1, \mu_2 = 1000, \sigma = 0.4$. The mixture is in a thermodynamic state with a reduced temperature $T = T'/\mathscr{T} = 0.1$ with T' measured in degrees Kelvin and a reduced number density $n = n'\mathscr{L}^3 = 0.1$ with n' measured in cm^{-3}. In the path integral we chose $M = 20$ and used either Bose-Einstein (case A in Table I) or Fermi-Dirac (case B in Table I) statistics among like particles. In the figures $r = r'/\mathscr{L}$ where r' is measured in centimeters.

AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflicts of interest

None declared.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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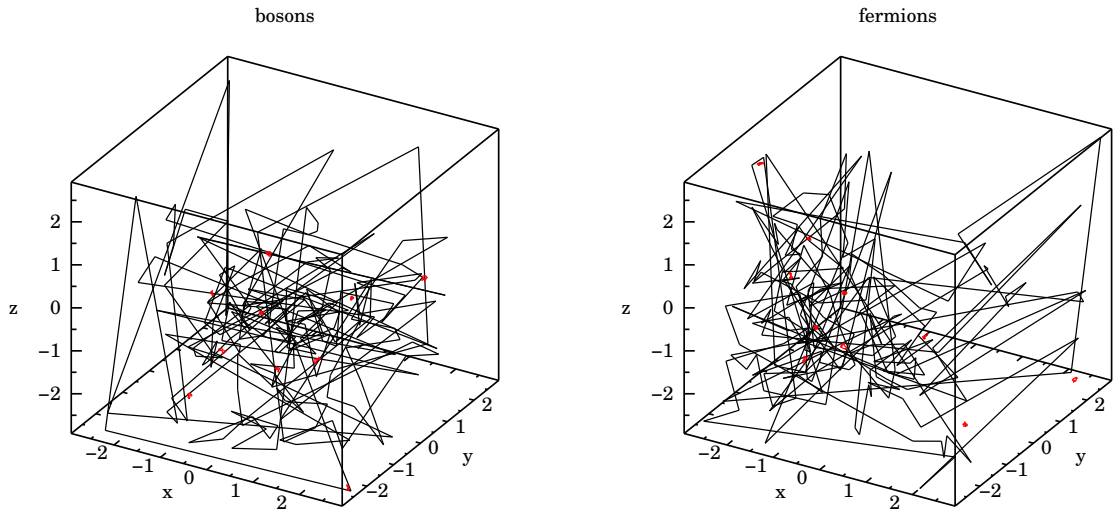

FIG. 2. Snapshots of the simulation of a binary mixture with $N = 20, x_1 = 1/2, \mu_1 = 1, \mu_2 = 1000, \sigma = 0.4$. The mixture is in a thermodynamic state with a reduced temperature $T = T'/\mathscr{T} = 0.1$ with T' measured in degrees Kelvin and a reduced number density $n = n'\mathscr{L}^3 = 0.1$ with n' measured in cm^{-3}. In the path integral we chose $M = 20$ and used either Bose-Einstein (left panel, case A in Table I) or Fermi-Dirac (right panel, case B in Table I) statistics among like particles. Red paths are for the heavy slow species and black paths are for the light fast species.

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